

Over the next couple of years, the Space Race would heat up and the Soviet Space Programme emerged as the leader. The Luna programme was launched to develop the first lunar probe. Although the Luna 1 was unsuccessful in doing so, it did become the first man-made object to reach Earth's escape velocity. The objective of the programme was successfully achieved when the Luna 2 became the first man-made object to reach the moon in 1959. Luna 3 rounded the Moon later that year, and returned the first photographs of its far side, which can never be seen from Earth.

Meanwhile, the US space programme also achieved some success through missions like the Explorer 6, which was the first artificial satellite to click photographs of the Earth from its own orbit.

Laika and Sputnik 5

As it became clear that the technology now existed to send man into orbit, the question was whether a living organism would be able to survive the launch and endure weightlessness. Like before, the Soviets turned to dogs to test this.

Laika, a stray dog, was chosen to be put aboard the Sputnik 2, which was launched mere months after the path-defining Sputnik 1 on November 3, 1957. Laika survived the launch and weightlessness, but died of heat inside the satellite.

At the time, the question to send the dog on the ill-fated mission wasn't questioned, but scientists involved in the programme have later expressed their regrets. One of them, Oleg Gazenko, later said, "Work with animals is a source of suffering to all of us. We treat them like babies who cannot speak. The more time passes, the more I'm sorry about it. We shouldn't have done it... We did not learn enough from this mission to justify the death of the dog."

Meanwhile, a separate spacecraft called the Vostok was built by the Soviet Union to make it easier and safer to go into space. In its third test flight in 1960, the Vostok carried the Sputnik 5 satellite with its crew of two dogs – Belka and Strelka – as well as two rats, 40 mice and a variety of plants. The spacecraft was able to successfully go into orbit and return thereafter with all its occupants alive, making it the first time living organisms had been in Earth's orbit and returned to the planet safely.

With the proof of model established, it was finally decided that the Russians would be sending a man into space soon... 